



OVER THE SIERRA MADRE

In 1929, TAT opened up an air-rail coast-to-coast route from Los Angeles to New York. Charles Lindbergh piloted the first leg of the inaugural flight in the Ford Tri-Motor City of Los Angeles. Here he flies along the Sierra Madre mountains.

journey was 20 hours faster than the trip by express train alone. However, this was not time-saving enough to attract many customers, especially after a TAT Tri-Motor flew into Mt. Taylor, Arizona, just two months after the service started, killing everyone on board. The air-rail experiment ended in 1930.

Night flights

The development of the US air-transportation network in the 1930s soon took it far beyond what had been achieved in Europe. One of the conditions of the contracts

awarded by the Postmaster General in 1930 was that airlines had to be experienced in operating by night as well as day. By 1933 there were 18,000 miles (28,800km) of lighted airway in the United States, and airlines were flying passengers coast-to-coast without recourse to overnight train travel. Provision for bad-weather flying also made giant strides. Radio navigation stations – transmitters of radio “beams” – were established at 200-mile (320-km) intervals along US airways. Already by 1929 it was possible to fly “on the beam” from Boston to Omaha via New York and Chicago.

